

How Should We View the Communist Party of India (Maoist)?

Zhihu

The CPI (Maoist) characterises Indian society as "semi-colonial and semi-feudal." In fact, it is not only the Maoists who say this — the other Marxist–Leninist parties in India arrive at more or less the same verdict. If this characterisation is correct, then the Maoists' strategy is correct as well, for in a semi-colonial, semi-feudal society the peasantry suffers oppression on every side, stands at the brink of ruin, and has no place to go for wage labour — which provides the deep social base for radical left-wing politics.

But is India really still a "semi-colonial, semi-feudal society"?

Economically: if India were a semi-colonial society, why did the Indian government's unilateral adjustment of tariffs provoke no intervention by the great powers? Why has India repeatedly performed the "pig-butcherer" trick on multinational corporations without ever being overthrown for it?

Politically: if India were a semi-colonial society, why has India's friendship with Russia — buying Russian oil and Russian weapons — drawn no sanctions from Europe and America?

As for whether India is semi-feudal, one only needs to look at agriculture's share of GDP to see that the landlord class can no longer be the dominant class force. In 1936, agriculture contributed over 60% of China's GDP; in 2025, Indian agriculture contributes less than 20% of GDP. The share of India's workforce employed in agriculture has fallen below 50%, and among the young it is lower still. India's current agricultural labour share is already below China's in 2000, and far below that of tsarist Russia in its final years. So rapid is India's industrial development that the south of India has even begun to experience a shortage of migrant labour. Although many feudal survivals remain in Indian society — the caste system, landlord ownership, and so on — on the whole, can India still be called a semi-feudal society? I fear not.

In fact, in the 1960s, when Charu Majumdar rose in revolt, agriculture still accounted for nearly 50% of India's GDP, so the anti-feudal land struggle in the countryside still had a certain social base. By 1990, agriculture's share of GDP had fallen to around 30%, and the base of the land revolution kept shrinking. Yet it was precisely in the 2000s, when India's economy was racing ahead after reform and opening up, that the CPI (Maoist) grew fastest, even occupying quasi-base areas holding tens of

millions of people. This was mainly due to the development of Indian capitalism, which pushed into the Adivasi tribal regions and thereby provided living space for anti-capitalist politics.

Local governments and corporations in India joined forces to oppress the tribal peoples, seizing land without fair compensation — very much like the arbitrary mining and land grabs that plagued China's countryside in the 1990s and 2000s. It is the wild expansion of the primitive accumulation of barbaric capitalism. As the Indian government passed laws protecting tribal land rights, and built bridges and roads, new schools, and brought electricity and the internet to these areas, the Maoists' living space was greatly eroded. With military encirclement steadily intensifying, the end of the CPI (Maoist)'s land revolution has become inevitable.

The Maoists' feat of holding the red flag high in the age of rampant neoliberalism has been moving, then and now. But the new changes in the mode of production demand that people re-examine reality and seek new paths on the basis of the new reality. At present, driven by domestic and international capital, India has entered a phase of rapid industrialisation; in about twenty-five years it will basically complete its industrialisation and urbanisation (see: "India is a major steel producer — why then is it said that India has not completed its industrialisation?"). The centre of gravity of India's social contradictions lies in the cities, not the countryside. What causes the masses' suffering is unemployment, not landlessness or high rents. The CJP movement, which has swept across India like a whirlwind of late, is proof of this.

Now that the capitalist world-system has reached the stage of transnational capitalism (see: "The Rise and Fall of the Capitalist World-System (III): An Analysis of the Contradictions of the Three Stages of the World-System"), production has crossed national borders in its entirety, and the economic analysis of any single country must be conducted against the background of the world-system. Chinese capital, for instance, is exporting to Africa, rapidly raising agricultural productivity and industrial capacity, and driving peasants into the cities to become workers. Are African countries still semi-colonial, semi-feudal societies? If they are semi-feudal, then transnational capital is helping the African countries abolish feudal survivals. If they are semi-colonial, why do the great powers not only permit African countries to raise tariffs and ban mineral exports, but even grant African countries zero tariffs to help their industrialisation? This can hardly be explained away by "aiding the enemy" or "diplomatic weakness."

Although the movement led by the CPI (Maoist) has failed, it won gains for the masses, and so it was not without fruit. In the future, the comrades of India will pass through even greater storms, whose scale and impact will far exceed the Maoists' struggle in the jungles.

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